Past tenses: simple, continuous, perfect, used to and would

Understand it

Past simple tells finished events in order. Past continuous paints the background (what was happening). Past perfect jumps back to something earlier. Used to and would describe old habits; only used to works for states (I used to live, not I would live).

Part 2 stories become band 7 when you combine these tenses naturally: one background verb, several main events, and one earlier event.

The rules

- Past simple: finished events. I visited Rome in 2019.
- Past continuous: an action in progress at that time. I was walking when it started to rain.
- Past perfect: the earlier of two past events. When I arrived, the film had started.
- Used to: past habits and states. I used to play football. Would: repeated past actions only (not states): Every summer we would visit my grandmother.

All the words and forms you need

Past simple	went · saw · decided · arrived · bought · met · felt
Past continuous	was / were + -ing (background, interrupted action)
Past perfect	had + past participle (earlier past)
Habits	used to + verb (habits and states) · would + verb (repeated actions only)
Time words	ago · last year · when · while · as · by the time · before that · eventually · in the end

Where you use it

Writing: Maps and charts about the past: A park was built where a factory had stood.

Speaking: Part 2: set the scene with past continuous, tell the main events with past simple, give background with past perfect.

Reading: Past perfect in a text shows what happened before the main events.

More examples

- I was walking home when it started to rain.
- By the time we arrived, the concert had already begun.
- When I was a child, I used to spend summers with my grandparents.

- We would go fishing every Sunday.
- I had never seen the sea before that trip.
- Eventually, we found the hotel.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ I was go to the shop yesterday.	✓ I went to the shop yesterday.
✗ When I came, they already left.	✓ When I came, they had already left.
✗ I would live in a village. (state)	✓ I used to live in a village.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Describe a trip you remember well.
2. What did you use to do as a child that you don't do now?
3. Tell me about a time you were late.
4. What was happening when you heard some important news?
5. Talk about a celebration you enjoyed.

Writing practice

Write a 4-sentence story about a lost phone using past continuous, past simple, past perfect and used to.

Practice

1. Choose: I (met / was meeting) her while I (studied / was studying).

2. Complete: By the time we arrived, the shop ___ (close).

3. Complete: She ___ (live) in London for ten years before she moved. (past perfect)

4. Rewrite with used to: When I was young, I played outside every day.

5. Correct: I have seen him yesterday.

6. Correct: He was having a car when he was 20.

Answers

1. met; was studying
2. had closed
3. had lived
4. I used to play outside every day.
5. I saw him yesterday.
6. He had a car when he was 20.